We picked up where we'd left off at Old Trafford the evening before. I got the feeling we were both talking away, trying to find the nerve to actually say what we meant. I'd already asked once, in Manchester, and eventually I got round to asking again:

'What are you doing later?'

'Nothing.'

'I'm in Manchester but I'll drive down. We could go out.'

Five hours later I was at the car wash in Chingford. First things first: the car had to look its best. I wasn't to know whether Victoria would be impressed with the new one, a blue BMW M3 convertible, but I wasn't taking any chances. I scrubbed it, hoovered it and by the time I got to my mum's I was looking in worse shape than the car had after the drive down. Mum knew I'd got Victoria's number at Old Trafford and I think she knew what was going on when I turned up on the doorstep. She wasn't too sure about the whole Spice Girls thing at all but she knew me better than to try talking me out of it: I'm as soft as she is but, when I get my heart set on something, I'm as stubborn as my dad.

'All right, David. It's up to you.'

She knew perfectly well she'd have no chance of changing my mind. On went clean clothes: a white t-shirt, a beige jacket, Timberlands and a pair of Versace jeans. It was like putting on my costume for the most important show ever. I rang the co-star and we arranged to meet—very swish setting—at a bus stop outside the Castle, a pub we both knew in Woodford. We worked out later that we'd been in that pub at exactly the same time as each other in the past but without realizing it.

She pulled up in her car, a purple-colored MG, and I went over. I climbed in the passenger seat. I was so nervous. *What should I do? Kiss her on the cheek? Shake hands?* With a little wobble in my voice, I mumbled:

'All right?'

I'd sorted out my car. I'd sorted out my wardrobe. I can't say I'd sorted out a plan for the evening.

'Where do you want to go?' Victoria smiled.